
Islamic Modernities? Citizenship, Civil Society and Islamism in a Nigerian City

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Perhaps the feeling that secular beliefs are rationally superior to religious ones is based on the belief that religious convictions are more rigid. But there is no decisive evidence for this. Religious traditions have undergone the most radical transformations over time. Divine texts may be unalterable, but the ingenuities of human interpretation are endless. . . . Fanatics come in all shapes and sizes among skeptics and believers alike . . . it must be said that the ruthlessness of secular practice yields nothing to the ferocity of the religious. . . . Islamic tradition is the ground on which . . . reasoning takes place [in the Muslim world]. And that is no more than may be said about political and moral reasoning within the modern liberal tradition.

Talal Asad 1993: 235–236 (emphasis added)

[Islamic] revivalism and reformism are thus a Janus-like creature. . . . Yet [they] . . . maintain a constant ambiguity, for on the one hand they

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advocate transformations of society, polity and culture that could have been advocated by any Latin American marxist political economist, while on the other they assimilate this to the notion of an independent and invariant [Muslim] historical subject. . . . Islamic radicalism [is] a very recent phenomenon, born of a particular specification. It specified jahiliyya, the non-Islam that is to be converted into Islamic order, as an actual presence.

Aziz Al-Azmeh 1993: 86, 99

[I]mplicitly "Christianity" is considered inherent to modern civilization . . . [but] why could Islam not do the same as Christianity? It seems to me rather that the absence of massive ecclesiastical organization of the Christian-Catholic type ought to make this adaptation easier. If it is admitted that modern civilization in its industrial-economic-political manifestation will end up by triumphing in the East . . . why not therefore conclude that Islam will necessarily evolve? Will Islam be able to remain just as it was? No—it is already no longer what it was before the war. Is it possible that it will fall at a stroke? Absurd hypothesis. . . . In actual fact the most tragic difficulty for Islam is given by the fact that a society in a state of torpor . . . has been put into brusque contact with a frenetic civilization already in its phase of dissolution.

Antonio Gramsci 1995: 133–134

Civil society is a protean term, a characteristic which might go some way toward explaining its current ubiquity in and outside of academia. None other than Francis Fukuyama who not so long ago was proclaiming the end of history has a new book—*Trust: The Social Virtues and the Creation of Prosperity*—in which he has rediscovered history in the form of “social capital,” that is to say civic institutions, which is going to save capitalism and make us all prosperous. Jean Cohen and Andrew Arato (1992) begin their massively intimidating book *Civil Society and Political Theory* by noting the resurrection, rebirth, and reconstruction of civil society, and its centrality in the post-socialist and post-military transitions in Eastern Europe and Latin America. Their concern, unlike Fukuyama, is with democratic theory and with a discourse of civil society oriented to the utopian ideas of modernity. In this sense there is an affinity between Cohen and Arato’s project on the reemergence of civil society and the sea change in contemporary political culture and Habermas’s discussion of the modern lifeworld

(which encompasses civil society) and the related concept of the public sphere. Civil society for Habermas is “composed of those associations which, within the framework of the arrangements of public spheres, institutionalize problem-solving discourses for questions of general interest” (1992: 455). The preconditions for the emergence of civil society are a plurality of lifeforms, public communications, and the legality of rights and regulation. Habermas too is concerned with democracy but he emphasizes that it is within civil society that disturbances in the symbolic realm of the lifeworld are first perceived, experienced, and resisted (Brenner 1993; Calhoun 1992). It is precisely this symbolic realm and its institutional character that has contributed to another aspect of the resurgence of civil society, to which Fukuyama’s book speaks, concerned with accumulation and development rather than democracy *per se*. Social capital—the social norms and institutionalized relationships which underwrite developmental resources—here invokes the networks of civil society as a precondition for trust, duty, and accountability within the domains of welfare and the economy (Putnam 1993; Evans 1995).

In all of this Africa stands as a depressing counterpoint. The conundrum seems to be the coexistence of weak societies and weak states which produces if not the collapse of civil society then something so fractured by cleavages and conflicts that it offers no effective resistance to state hegemony and no semblance of civil society either. One line of popular apocalyptic writing points to a sort of withdrawal and collapse; a combination of war, decay, and anarchy (Kaplan 1994a; Hitchens 1994).¹ It is frequently the African metropolis which appears as the crucible for this decay, for a civil society gone awfully wrong. Lagos, every world traveler’s worst nightmare, is naturally the apogee, a city of “capitalism gone wild” as the *Los Angeles Times* (24 February 1983, 10) put it. The *New Republic* was no less enthralled: “Impoverished, filthy, steamy, overcrowded and corrupt, Lagos is the ultimate incarnation of the modern megalopolis gone to hell” (12 July 1993, 11). In some respects these sorts of narratives could be reproduced for most African cities. Here for example is an account of Cairo taken from the *New Yorker* (Weaver 1995: 55), but it could easily be replicated (see Ajami 1995; Kaplan 1994b):

1. Kaplan’s image of Africa sliding back into Victorian darkness as he put it, was picked up widely in the U.S. press, but these sentiments also appear within the left community, for example, Christopher Hitchens in *Vanity Fair*: “what if all this bloodshed is for nothing? What if Africa is neither cleansed in blood nor giving birth in blood but just plain *drowning* in blood” (November 1994, 102).

People seemed to be living on the edge, as much of the city's infrastructure was being reduced to dust. Corruption flourished and political stagnation ossified. . . . Every year Egypt produces more than a hundred thousand university graduates, many of whom cannot find jobs . . . the city's once astonishing diversity of cultures and social strata has seemingly been reduced to two starkly contrasting poles: poverty, which appeared everywhere, and extraordinary wealth.

I want to explore civil society in metropolitan Africa by taking the case of Kano and by using local Islam as a vehicle for exploring the public spheres in which communicative action and associational life takes place. Kano is in no sense a typical Nigerian city, should such a thing exist; neither is it, in any simple sense, medieval or Islamic. The level of homicide, violence, and robbery is certainly lower than Lagos and probably less than comparable European and American cities (Last 1991: 3). Urban gangs have proliferated to the point where the State government declared them unlawful in 1983, and Kano residents complain, as city residents generally do everywhere, about the increase of crime. But this is not the stuff of *Bladerunner* either. Kano moreover has a substantial associational life; some 250 associations and self-help groups were registered in 1991 including religious groups, market associations, neighborhood networks, and vigilante groups. But it is the fundamental presence of Islam which dominates the landscape of urban civil society, and it is the growth of Islamism within the city that provides the entrée for my discussion of the Kano public sphere. I shall use the well-documented case of a fundamentalist Muslim movement²—Maitatsine—in the 1970s and 1980s (Lubeck 1985, 1986; Watts 1994), a movement which almost pulled Kano city apart in 1980, to explore one small part of the changing landscape of citizenship, identity, and associational life in the city. This story reveals how a distinctive Muslim community was built, as it were, *within* a Muslim community, and to tell it I shall have to trace the dialectical relations between a local social structure of Islam and a local social structure of capitalist accumulation driven by globalization of a certain sort, namely the oil

2. By Islamic fundamentalism, Islamism, Islamic revanchism/revivalism and political Islam—terms I take to be roughly interchangeable—I refer to a scripturalist form of religious piety affirming the centrality of the Qu'ran and the hadith for all aspects of life and practice, and the advocacy of a political order whose topos is “none other than the order of rectitude that reigned at the time of the Prophet Mohammed . . . the order described in the voluminous corpus of quasi-sacred narrative scripture called the hadith” (Al-Azmeh 1993: 25). It is, in short, the politicized retrieval of an essence, “that the vicissitudes of time and the designs of enemies, rather than change of any intrinsic nature, had caused to atrophy” (42).

boom. I have employed the metaphor of mapping to inform the ways in which these two locally constituted global force-fields—Islam and capitalism—informed each other, and thereby challenged, reconfigured, and reconstituted some aspects of urban identity and civil society. To employ the language of Carl Schorske (1981), I want to examine the “reshuffling of the self” associated with an emergent Islamic modernity rooted in the long engagement of Islam with the capitalist “West.” In this instance, as in so many others within the contemporary Muslim world, this engagement takes the form of a struggle over Muslim orthodoxy, what Talal Asad calls “a reordering of knowledge that governs the ‘correct’ form of Islamic practices” (1993: 210), in the context of radical social and economic change in a big, sprawling urban metropolis in northern Nigeria.

My account of the genesis of Maitatsine as a form of revivalism or political Islam raises a larger issue of the relations between Islam, civil society, and modernity. “At the heart of the revivalist worldview,” says John Esposito, “is the belief that the Muslim world is in a state of decline” (1992: 19). But what sort of explanation of, and alternative to, decline does Islamism offer? Specifically, what sort of utopian vision of civil society did Maitatsine contribute, and how does it figure in relation to wide-ranging reformist debates within the Muslim diaspora in Nigeria? These questions tread on territory that cannot be adequately covered here but it is the widespread essentialist vision of Muslim societies, held even among scholars sympathetic to Islam, that fundamentalisms in particular are “static, reactive, anti-modern and rageful” (cited in Lubeck 1995: 3), that I wish to explore. Central to the relations between the public sphere and Islam is whether Islamism “gives primevalism and primitivism precedence over history” (Al-Azmeh 1993: 93). In this Weberian model of Islam, the prospects for civil society are grim to say the least. Al-Azmeh dismisses Islamism as utopian, ahistorical, and proto-fascist wedded to a sort of Romantic hypernationalism; for Turner fundamentalism offers nostalgia, cultural antimodernism, and a limited sense of political pluralism built around “the household of faith” (1993: 93). Ernest Gellner sees the urban ethos and a puritanical, reformed, legally oriented, and powerful clergy (*ulama*) as conducive to disciplined capitalist accumulation (1983, 1992). But civil society disappears altogether and politics is condemned to stagnation and eternal elite circulation. It is to these larger questions that I wish to make the Kano case speak.

Refiguring Kano: From Mercantile to Industrial Capitalism

The economic crisis . . . has altered old priorities [in Kano]: the leftover food that could be given as alms is much reduced . . . the casual jobs are

even lower paid if valued in terms of what grain the wages might buy. . . . Marriages are postponed for want of money; fewer wives are taken even by the well-to-do . . . unemployment for the young seems unremitting. They are not a high priority for food or work; hardship . . . is again attributed a moral quality.

Murray Last 1991: 19–20

A bustling, kinetic city forged in the crucible of seventeenth- and eighteenth-century trans-Saharan trade, Kano is the economic fulcrum of northern Nigeria standing at the heart of the country's most populous state, currently numbering over ten million people. An ancient walled city whose ironworkings date back to the seventh century, Kano was comparable in size and significance to Cairo and Fez by the mid-sixteenth century, and by 1750 it was a city of international stature and cosmopolitan urbanity. As Murray Last put it, Kano scholars owned books written in Arabic by scholars in southern Russia; its language, Hausa, could be heard in nineteenth-century Brazil and Istanbul (1991: 4). A vital manufacturing center in the precolonial period, Kano's high quality cloth was exported to Europe and to other parts of Africa; its pivotal location in long distance trade facilitated the movement of commodities, ideas, and people from the Muslim diaspora of North Africa to Christian societies along the West African coastal corridor.

While Islam was adopted in Kano in the fourteenth century, it was not until the reforms of Sarkin Muhammadu Rumfa (1463–1499) that the institutional foundations were laid which would eventually convert the city into a metropolis renowned throughout the Islamic world. The spatial and cultural morphology of the city—its labyrinthine and aleatory structure, its massive mud ramparts, the close juxtaposition of the emir's palace, the central mosque, and the market, as well as its armed forces, shari'ah law, and ward-level policing systems—resembled, in its broad outlines, urban Islamic culture across the Middle East. Until the end of the sixteenth century the leading clerics (*ulama*) in Kano were temporary immigrants most of whom left the city; by the mid-seventeenth century, however, Kano had firmly secured a reputation for producing its own Muslim clerics and saints (Barkindo 1993; Last 1988). In the wake of the nineteenth century Sokoto *jihād* whose leader, Shaikh Usman dan Fodio, adopted Qadriyya as a kind of official Sufi order, Kano emerged as perhaps *the* leading urban center of religious scholarship within the Sokoto Caliphate, itself the largest precolonial state system in all of sub-Saharan Africa, attracting scholars and students from a huge catchment area. As a center of trade, manufacture, learning, and Muslim piety, nine-

teenth-century Kano was a complexly differentiated, multi-ethnic and class-stratified city with a transnational outlook and composition. Islamic affiliation—the majority of Kano residents (*kanawa*) belonged to the Maliki *madhhab* and the Qadiriyya Sufi order—constituted the moral and political compass for Kano emirate and the Caliphal structure of which it was part, providing the ideological blueprint for the city's polity and civil society.

Little more than a half century of British colonial rule (1903–1960) radically refigured the political economy of northern Nigeria, and of Kano in particular, without at all contesting the ideological hegemony of Islam or the institutional dominance of the Sufi orders within civil society. Located at the center of a rich and densely settled (peasant) agricultural and trading system, the city emerged within a decade of colonial conquest as West Africa's preeminent entrepôt whose mercantile prospects were wrapped up with the fortunes of a single world commodity: the peanut. If the class prerogatives of the Muslim ruling elites (*masu sarauta*) within the old emirate structure were enhanced by their conversion into bureaucrats for the colonial Native Administration system, the economic opportunities afforded by a dynamic import-export trade underwrote the growth of a wealthy and powerful class of local mercantile capitalists, who in some respects stood as a counterweight to the powers of the Caliphal system. Furthermore, the social and ethnic composition of the city was transformed as “southerners” (Yoruba, Ibo, and Ibibio peoples in particular) flocked to the city, drawn by an expanding trade economy and by clerical and other jobs within the colonial administration available to English speakers with a secondary school training. Outside the old walled city (*birni*), southern Nigerians, Lebanese, North Africans, and a motley group of Europeans settled in a number of new suburbs collectively referred to as *waje*. To the residents of old Kano, *waje* was little more than a repository of permissiveness, westernization in its panoply of forms, and non-Muslim strangers. On the whole however, the *birni* passively resisted the European and stranger onslaught (Barkindo 1993). Up until 1970 there was no modern restaurant or bar within the walled city, and the School of Arabic Studies and the Judicial School were the only Western post-primary institutions within the *birni* proper.

If the cultural and social consequences of peanuts and peanut oil were, to a certain extent, held at arm's length during the colonial epoch, it was oil of an altogether different sort—petroleum—that ushered in a new, and in some respects a more radical transformation of Kano city during the halcyon days of the 1970s. Awash in petro-dollars, urban Kano was transformed during the 1970s from a traditional Muslim mercantile center of 400,000 people at the end of the Civil

War (1970), into a sprawling, ill-planned, and somewhat anarchic metropolis of over one million ten years later. Seemingly overnight Kano emerged as a fully fledged industrial periphery; employment in the industrial manufacturing sector was roughly 11,000 in 1969 and close to 60,000 before the retrenchments of the mid-1980s (Main 1989). The cultural heart of Kano, the old walled city, was now fully engulfed by the new suburbs sprouting up outside the walls. Suburbanization had its origins earlier in the century, of course, but large scale immigration, coupled with unplanned state-sponsored urban growth, expanded in the 1970s and thereby eroded the autonomy and social standing of the traditional Hausa core of the city as ever more *yan birni* (sons of the city) settled in *waje* or earned their living there.³ The relatively impervious membrane that had separated the *birni* from *waje* was already porous by the late 1960s. But it was the oil boom which finally marked the blurring of the boundary between the old and the new quarters of the city. At the zenith of the petroleum boom, new industrial estates dotted with Lebanese, Egyptian, and European enterprises sprung up at Challawa and Sharada along the city's periphery, armies of migrants poured into the city, and the icons of urban modernity—massive state-sponsored building and infrastructural projects—reshaped the city skyline. Kano was part construction site and part theater of orgiastic consumption. It had become a modern city in which “dishes for satellite television dominate the compounds of the rich whose wealth is growing ever more disproportionate as austerity . . . hits the poor. A watch for \$17,000; a house for \$2 million; private jets to London or the Friday prayer at Mecca” (Last 1991: 4).

The reconfigurations of urban life, community relations, and styles of consumption in urban Kano were driven in the first instance by a ferocious state-led modernization program fuelled by petroleum revenues (the 1973–74 and 1978–79 price hikes orchestrated by OPEC leveraged up the price of oil from US\$5 to US\$40 per barrel). Three times the total gross domestic product of contemporary sub-Saharan Africa—US\$140 billion—was banked by the Nigerian state between 1970 and 1983. Government revenues exploded, growing at close to 40% per annum during the 1970s (Watts 1994). Oil price hikes in 1973–74 and subsequently in 1978–79, permitted the Nigerian state to unleash a torrent of federal

3. For Kano citizens (*kanawa*), the city's cultural heart is the walled city, the *birni*. From 1903 onwards, the suburbs (*waje*) outside the walled city expanded, populated in the first instance by Westerners and by Nigerians from the south of the country. As Barkindo notes, *waje* was an evil to be tolerated but “this view radically changed from about 1970 onwards” (1993: 94).

investments, not least in the industrial sector: the Nigerian national index of manufacturing output, for example, almost tripled between 1972 and 1980. Under a succession of military governments between 1972 and 1979, the absolute number of manufacturing establishments and of industrial wage workers, the scale of direct investment by multinationals, and the shares of federal and regional state capital in industrial output, all witnessed positive growth rates. Black gold promised, for the chosen few at any rate, the “dawn of prosperity and progress for the petroleum rich” (Amuzegar 1982: 814).

Fifteen years later the luster of the oil boom had tarnished. Nigeria’s economic future appeared by contrast to be quite bleak, if not altogether austere. Spiralling debt – fuelled by a seemingly insatiable appetite for imports – the collapse of oil prices in the early 1980s, and the onslaught of Draconian neo-liberal programs imposed by the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund contributed to a precipitous recession. The “oil fortress,” to employ the language of *Le Monde* (2 October 1994, 15), had been rocked. Nigeria’s roller-coaster economy had irrevocably altered the everyday life of all sectors of society. Like other Nigerian cities, Kano’s experience of a rather spectacular commodity boom was felt, and here I borrow from Walter Benjamin (1973), as a “shock” of modernity. Indeed, it was from within this world awash with money and power that – to return to Habermas – the system gradually invaded, and partially colonized the lifeworld, and in so doing the very idea of Muslim identity and correct Muslim practice came to be challenged and contested.

Changing Identities in the Urban Landscape: Millenarian Islam and Capitalist Modernity in Kano

Emergent modernism has tended to take the specific form of . . . a “reshuffling of the self.” Here historical change not only forces upon the individual a search for a new identity but also imposes upon whole social groups the task of revising or replacing defunct beliefs.

Carl Schorske 1981: xviii

Eternal religious truths, like other beliefs, are perceived, understood and transmitted by persons historically situated in “imagined” communities, who knowingly or inadvertently contribute to the reconfiguration or interpretation of those verities, even as their fixed and unchanging natures are affirmed.

Dale Eickelman and James Piscatori 1990: 20

Born into rural poverty in 1927 in northern Cameroon, Mohammedu Marwa (alias Mallam Maitatsine alias Muhammedu Marwa alias Muhammedu Mai Tabsiri) left his birthplace when he was about sixteen years old. He attached himself to a local Muslim cleric and apparently displayed exceptional brilliance in the Qu'ranic science of exegesis (*tafsir*). His exegetical skills were acquired as a student (*almajirai*) in local Muslim networks and nonformal schools (*makarantar allo*). Settling in Kano city around 1945, he was a regular visitor at the preaching sessions around Shahauci and Fagge grounds in the old quarters of the city, providing unorthodox interpretations of Qu'ranic verses read by an associate, Mallam Aminu Umar or Limanu, who had returned from learning "in the East." Marwa insisted that the Qu'ran was the *only* valid guide to behavior and belief, and thus rejected both the Sunnah and the Shari'ah.⁴ According to the official Tribunal on the causes of the Kano riots, Maitatsine preached that "any Muslim who reads any book besides the Koran is a pagan" (1981a: 26). The basis of his inflammatory reading of the Qu'ran rested on a stripping away of the hidden meanings in the sacred text by rooting his analyses of verse in local, that is to say West African conditions. In particular by playing on the meanings and phonetic associations of certain Arabic and Hausa words, Marwa or Maitatsine as he became known locally, provided a powerful literalist and on occasion antimaterialist thrust to the Qu'ran. His vehement denunciation of bicycles, western apparel, cigarettes, buttons, cars, and so on brought him his name, Maitatsine, derived from the Hausa adage, "*Allah ta tsine* (God will curse)." By 1962, Marwa had gained some local notoriety as a troublesome, charismatic, and unorthodox preacher, and Emir Sanusi of Kano actually brought him to trial. He was imprisoned for three months and promptly deported. Marwa's local stature grew substantially, however, following his prediction that Emir Sanusi would fall from power, he was ousted several years later in the wake of the military coup.

Marwa returned to Kano shortly after his deportation—sustaining the popular belief that reactionary forces in high places supported his variety of militant political Islam—and continued to live and preach in the city. He was arrested and imprisoned again in 1966–67 and also in 1973–75, but was not deported.

4. Shari'ah (the path of God) is Islamic law in the form of a set of divinely revealed principles derived from the Qu'ran, from the example of the Prophet, and from tradition: it is applied by judges in Shari'ah courts. Sunnah customarily refers to good conduct or highly desirable acts based on the example of the Prophet, tradition, and reason. Maitatsine denounced the Sunnah as being made "only for Arabs."

In the period following Marwa's return to Kano City, the open spaces of 'Yan Awaki and Kofar Wombai, liminal neighborhoods within the city that were associated with gangs and a lumpen urban culture, provided a sort of beachhead, a sanctuary in which his students could be housed in makeshift dwellings which by the late 1970s included gardens to sustain the growing numbers of followers. By 1979 something like a community had been built and Maitatsine's compound in 'Yan Awaki housed at least 3000 persons.⁵ Witness number forty-nine to the official Government Tribunal, Uzairu Abdullahi, was one such Hausa disciple recruited from Niger eleven months prior to the insurrection (1981b: 58). At the suggestion of Maitatsine, the followers carried little or no money: to sleep with more than one naira (US\$.75) was to exhibit a lack of trust in Allah. They also dressed simply, begged for alms or worked as transient laborers in occupations typically reserved for dry-season migrants (*'yan cin-rani*) such as cart-pushing, tea-selling, and petty trade.

Maitatsine's followers (*yantatsine*) became increasingly visible around the old city, operating in small groups of three to five people, preaching at major junctions near the Sabon Gari mosque, around Koki, and at Kofar Wombai. Through recitations and unorthodox interpretations of the Qu'ran, the students vigorously attacked materialism, unjust leaders, corrupt *ulama*, and all followers of the powerful Sufi brotherhoods (*darikat*) who were deemed to be non-Muslim.⁶ Unorthodox behavior fuelled rumor on a grand scale. Kano's wealthiest contractors and some of the most powerful voices of the northern oligarchy, popular opinion had it, energetically supported the Maitatsine movement. Hearsay had it that Maitatsine was lent support in the period after the return to civilian rule in 1979 by luminaries within both the ruling party, the conservative and northern Muslim-dominated National Party of Nigeria (NPN), and perhaps from the incumbent Kano state administration (the populist Peoples' Redemption Party, PRP). Local

5. Maitatsine's diaspora extended across much of northern Nigeria and into the southern Niger Republic, a region sharing a cultural kinship with the Hausa heartland in Nigeria. These networks provided fertile recruiting grounds for students (*almajirai*) and aspirant lay clerics (*gardawa*).

6. Rooted in Muslim mysticism, a Sufi master (*shaykh*) typically associated himself with a founding saint and a brotherhood or order distinguished by initiation and other rituals. In northern Nigeria there are two main Sufi orders to which men and women belong: *Qadiriyya* was founded by Abd al-Qadir Jilani who lived and taught in Baghdad until his death in 1166 A.D. after which his ideas and teachings were introduced into West Africa by Arabo-Berber lineages; and *Tijaniyya* which takes its name from Ahman al-Tijani, a cleric of southern Algeria who lived in Fez until his death in 1815. The order was spread in West Africa by El Hajj Umar who introduced Tijanniyya into Nigeria through the Sultan of Sokoto Muhammed Bello in the first part of the nineteenth century.

rumor fed the mystique of Maitatsine's magical powers. The Tribunal reported grotesque (but largely unsubstantiated) tales of cannibalism, human slaughter (a "human spare parts department" as the local northern press referred to it), mass graves, drugged students, and brainwashed women (Yusuf 1988). At the same time, there were reports in the press of the extraordinary bravery, and impressive self-discipline of the *'yantatsine*. Indeed there was something like a moral economy within the community. Sometime in 1979, according to testimony by one of his wives, Marwa apparently declared his own prophethood.

On 26 November 1979, the Governor of Kano State wrote to Marwa demanding an evacuation of the quarter within two weeks. Originally intending to vacate 'Yan Awaki, Marwa apparently changed his mind, and promptly sent out a letter to diaspora communities calling in reinforcements to fight the "infidels." The *'yantatsine* planned to overrun and take control of the Friday Mosque in Kano, NEPA (the national electricity utility company), and the emir's palace. In their denunciation of the Government and their demand to appropriate "all land in the name of Allah," there was an allusion at least to some sort of seizure of state power. On 18 December 1980, four police units were sent to Shahauci playground near the emir's palace to arrest some of Maitatsine's preachers. Disorganized police forces were ambushed by "fanatics"—the language is taken from the influential northern newspapers the *New Nigerian* and *Gaskiya ta fi Kwabo*—armed with bows and arrows, daggers and machetes. According to the official Tribunal:

The fanatics in procession and many more emerging from the cover provided by onlookers . . . launched an attack on the Police . . . using machetes, bows and arrows, swords and clubs, dane guns, daggers and other similar weapons . . . while attacking they kept shouting "Kefri, Kefri" meaning infidels. (1981a: 28)

The *'yantatsine* burned police vehicles and seized arms. By late afternoon a huge plume of smoke hung over the city. Over the next few days, in a climate of growing chaos and popular fear, fighting spread and casualties mounted. By 21 December, with the police effectively unable to control the situation, vigilante groups entered the scene, and complex negotiations ensued between local authorities and the Kano State Governor Abubakar Rimi, who feared the imposition of martial law by the Federal Government and hence for his own political survival. On 22 December *'yantatsine* were reportedly entering Kano to join the insurrection (six bus loads of supporters from Sokoto were intercepted en route to Kano) while trucks full of corpses were seen leaving the city.

After five days of stalemate, confusion, and escalating violence, the army intervened on 29 December with ten hours of mortar barrage, supported by air bombardment. Incurring major losses, the 'yantatsine escaped and marched out of the city into the western districts along the Gwarzo road. Maitatsine led the exit from the 'Yan awaki quarter following the ferocious bombardment by state security and military forces but was injured and died in the western districts outside the city walls. His body was removed from a shallow grave and kept at a local mortuary for several days before it was cremated at the request of local authorities, presumably to prevent martyrdom among his converts and followers. Within days, photographs of Maitatsine's body (apparently illicitly taken into, and smuggled out of, the Kano Police department) were hot-selling items pedaled by young boys at busy intersections in the city.⁷

Petrolic Capitalism

Oil creates the illusion of a completely changed life, life without work, life for free. . . . Oil is a resource that anesthetizes thought, blurs vision, corrupts. . . . Look at the ministers from oil countries, how high they hold their heads, what a sense of power.

Ryszard Kapuchinski 1982: 35

The 1970s was the decade of oil, of bristling petrolic nationalism. Twenty-eight Third World states were petroleum exporters; each was able to capture, in varying measure, very substantial oil rents leveraged from a petroleum-dependent world by the success of OPEC's cartel. For OPEC-member states, petroleum became the lynchpin of the national economy, representing on average at least three-quarters of national export earnings in 1980. Oil producers were, and remain, however a heterogeneous lot: Lilliputian city-states like Qatar with limited capacity to absorb the revenues locally stand in sharp contrast to populous so-called "high-absorbers" like Indonesia, Venezuela, and Mexico. Nigeria stands, in this

7. According to the official Tribunal figures, 4177 people died (excluding police and military) but the human toll was clearly much greater. Some quite reliable estimates range as high as 10,000; 15,000 were injured and 100,000 rendered homeless. The physical damage was enormous: in Fagge 82 houses and 249 shops were destroyed; in 'Yan Awaki 165 houses were destroyed and heavily damaged. Of the 917 people arrested, 12% were juveniles and 185 were non-Nigerian. Many thousands of Maitatsine's supporters avoided arrest and scattered to various states in the north. Between 1981 and 1985 four more incidents occurred between Maitatsine's followers and state authorities in urban and quasi-urban locations across northern Nigeria; perhaps 4000 to 5000 persons died in these conflagrations.

regard, as an archetypical high-absorber since domestic petroleum output in the 1970s, roughly 1.3 million barrels per day, was sufficient to “absorb” substantial domestic state expenditures. Ironically, as a consequence of the oil boom, Nigeria became more of a monocultural economy than it had ever been in the colonial era: 95.3% of total export revenues derived from oil, and almost two-thirds of government revenue was dependent upon the petroleum sector. Average annual growth rates for credit, money supply, and state expenditures were exceptional: respectively 45%, 66%, and 91% between 1973 and 1980.

How, then, can we begin to grasp the character of Nigeria’s petrolic-modernization—the fast capitalism unleashed by the oil boom—and its implications for Kano civil society? Two rather obvious points at the outset. First, oil is an, and in some respects *the*, archetypical global commodity. It necessarily projects producers fully into the vortex of international circuits of capital and global finance. To this extent one might talk of a globalization of the Nigerian economy and polity. The second is that the enclave character of the oil industry combined with the fact that oil revenues typically flow directly into national treasuries, has profound implications for state centralization and for state embeddedness. In this sense, the disposition of oil through fiscal linkages acts as a powerful centralizing force at the level of the state, which is projected into civil society (i.e., localized or domesticated) via expanded forms of public ownership, investment, and service provision. In other words, Nigeria’s oil boom was transformative along at least three dimensions: through an ostensibly new relationship with the world economy, through a new strategy of capital accumulation as oil earnings overwhelmed previous sources of state surplus, and through a process of state centralization and state-led import substitution. Each of these vectors directly shaped the contours of civil society providing the ether in which debates of Islamic modernity were bathed.

The genesis of an enlarged state as the mediator of the oil boom appears with particular clarity in Nigeria in the aftermath of the first oil shock. State centralization had commenced during the civil war but the creation of new regional states (nineteen states from four autonomous regions) deepened the fiscal dependency on a federal purse through statutory revenue allocation procedures. At the same time, the multiplication of states in the wake of the first oil boom vastly expanded the magnitude of the bureaucracy at all levels of government. Creeping state bureaucratization was seen in a variety of guises: capital expenditures at the federal level increased by 800% in real terms between 1973 and 1980, the number of parastatals mushroomed from almost nothing in 1970 to over 800 in 1980; the number of federal employees leapt to 280,000. In the period after 1975

under the Murtala and Obasanjo military administrations (1975–1979), the state wage bill and the state-owned industrial sector reached their apotheosis. The federal government encouraged auto-assembly and initiated an ambitious capital and intermediate goods program including an iron and steel sector, petrochemicals, and light engineering. In the same way that oil promised for the Shah of Iran a Great Civilization, so did effortless money produce boundless ambition in Nigeria. El Dorado had been located; it was an oil well.

Naturally the rise of a centralized, bureaucratic petro-state with earnings in 1980 in excess of US\$25 billion had serious implications for politics and class rule in Nigeria. The regional elites no longer depended on access to surpluses generated by peasant producers but on oil rents redistributed through the state apparatuses. Indeed, while the military-civil servant alliance maintained its precarious northern political hegemony, the vastly expanded oil revenues bankrolled a huge rent-seeking edifice, a “flabby and heterogeneous dominant coalition preoccupied with a grabbing of public resources . . . through an elaborate network of patronage and subsidies” (Bardhan 1980: 82). Not only did the state embark upon a massive program of infrastructural and industrial modernization—attempting to lay the groundwork for systematic capitalist accumulation—but these expenditures became the means by which petrodollars created pacts and coalitions within a national polity sharply divided along regional, ethnic, and religious lines. Patronage, contracting, and subsidies were part and parcel of the desperate political struggle to win control of the state which was privatized in the specific sense that public office became, to employ Max Weber’s language, a *prebend*, i.e., a public position to be used for personal gain. Corruption flourished on a gargantuan scale; in fact the entire local and federal bureaucratic environment was astonishingly indisciplined, chaotic, and venal. In the wake of the return to civilian rule in 1979 these state incapacities reached new levels of malfeasance and inefficiency. Government became more than ever, as Nigerian novelist Chinua Achebe (1988) observed in his novel *Anthills of the Savannas*, a “crummy family business.”

To summarize, there were several key ways in which oil-driven globalization of the boom period fundamentally reconfigured the national, regional, and urban spaces in which Islamism operated and flourished. The first was a commodity boom. Nigeria began to “import all importables” as Frishman put it (1988: 12); Nigerian merchandise imports (capital, intermediary, and consumer goods) increased from N1.1 billion in 1973 to N14.6 billion in 1981. Propelled by new federal and state bureaucracies and the infusion of money unleashed by government-mandated (Udoji Commission) salary increases in 1975, the oil boom be-

came a consumer spending spree. Everything from stallions to stereos exchanged hands in Kano, a sort of commodity fetishism that one commentator aptly described as a Nigerian “cargo cult.” The second source of local transformation was a gargantuan state-financed urban construction boom; the capital expenditures of Kano state grew at an average rate of 57% between 1973 and 1980! The construction industry (roads, office construction, industrial plant) grew by at least 20% per annum in the 1970s, sucking rural labor into dynamic but hopelessly unplanned cities such as Kano.

Furthermore, the boom in oil had the effect of both depressing and distorting non-oil sectors, particularly agriculture and the rural sector. A shortage of labor combined with the inflation of input costs, created a profit squeeze for many peasant producers reflected in a depressed agricultural sector and in the collapse of traditional exports (cocoa, groundnuts, palm oil effectively disappeared). Food imports, particularly wheat which became a new staple of the urban poor, increased sharply, prompting a series of expensive state irrigation schemes to produce wheat for the local market. Socially disruptive, and a source of lavish rents for contractors, politicians, and the military, these schemes contributed less to national food self-sufficiency than to the growth of land speculation and growing economic inequality in the countryside associated with the rise of so-called overnight farmers and farmer-trader speculators. The oil boom, in short, had manufactured rural-urban drift, social dislocation in the countryside, and a sense—confirmed in many other aspects of social life—of state corruption and violence.

In Nigerian history, the oil boom of the 1970s stands between the first tentative postcolonial efforts at import-substituting industrialization in the 1960s and the oil bust and economic neo-liberalism of the 1980s and 1990s. In this sense, petrolic capitalism and Fordist style state-led industrialization in Nigeria has a much wider resonance. A swath of Middle Eastern political economy can also be located on this larger canvas of the shift from import substitution during the so-called “Golden Age” of North Atlantic Fordism (1950–1970) to the OPEC price revolution from 1973 to 1982 and the surge of state-centered development⁸ to the commodity crash, recession, and liberal reforms (*infatih*) of the last fifteen years. In all such instances, the globalizing impact of the oil boom set the stage

8. The state development occurred against a backdrop of international inflation, declining real incomes, and the dissolution of Keynesian coalitions. Richards (1995) and Richards and Waterbury (1990) have documented for Egypt, for example, the turn from the 1960s (a period of retarded job creation, depressed agriculture, and fostered rural-urban migration) to the oil boom which raised urban incomes, stimulated inflation and rent-seeking, and distorted the economy.

for “the crisis of the secular nationalist state once the [oil] rents were spent” (Lubeck 1995: 18). Even before the neo-liberal reforms, the oil boom had globalized the economies of oil exporters, disrupted social, cultural, and political economic relations, and laid the foundations for the first Islamic political revolution in Iran in 1979. During the 1980s, globalization took the form not of a commodity boom but of a commodity bust and recession followed by economic liberalization under the auspices of international regulatory institutions. Nigeria, like other oil exporters, experienced 1980s neo-liberalism in a particularly savage form because of the precipitous economic decline, itself a function of the fact that the oil rents were unearned windfalls. The chilly winds of adjustment and economic reform which blew into the OPEC world in the 1980s may have stimulated transnational manufacturing and the internationalization of financial activity but they simultaneously undercut the entire state-led industrial strategy and the rent-seeking, i.e., politically targeted subsidies, which it sustained. If the crisis of the 1970s was about the failure of state-centered development to deliver improved living standards, public accountability, and democracy, the globalization and radical restructuring of the state which occurred in the name of neo-liberal rectitude during the 1980s and 1990s rendered a crisis of another sort: spending cutbacks, the collapse of already tattered social services, declining real wages, public sector layoffs, and the growing presence of foreign transnationals (i.e., the specter of foreign control and westernization). Islamism clearly predated the oil boom just as some new forms of political Islam have emerged in the wake of the oil bust. But the central question remains how and whether, in light of the historically contingent forms that globalization assumes, Muslims (radical, militant, or moderate) can make Islamic traditions speak to and interpolate the particular senses of frustration, despondency, and interest thrown up in the interstices of national economies coping with the demands of the new global economy (see Lubeck 1995).

Experiencing Fast Capitalism in Kano City

This letter is from the Prophet Mohammed. It came from Medina to Mecca . . . to Wadi . . . to Kukawa . . . to Bornoland. . . . From there to Hadejia . . . to Kano and from Kano to the whole world. The Prophet said there will be disaster of the wind, poverty, death of sheep and ill-health of women and men. The ill-health of women and men will affect their womanhood

and manhood respectively. It would affect the old and the young of women and men East and West, South and North.

Letter circulated by Maitatsine followers and published in *The New Nigerian*, 3 March 1984

How was the peculiar configuration of oil, state, and commodification “experienced” in Kano, and quite specifically how was civil society and the public sphere invaded under the onslaught of what Habermas (1991) calls the “irresistible inner dynamics of the systemic sphere,” the “steering media” of power and money? I want to suggest that the question of experience contains two aspects. On one hand, the oil boom was experienced in class terms and yet the social and cultural character of this class experience in Kano was, to use Marx’s language, inherited from the past and was irreducibly local. The central social class we must consider is the self-conscious popular strata in northern Nigerian society identified locally as commoners or *talakawa*. On the other hand, the roller-coaster ride on Nigeria’s fast capitalist track was experienced explicitly, to employ language from Gramsci’s *Prison Notebooks*, in relation to “ethico-political” hegemony, that is to say on the terrain of civil society and cultural order, and the discursive frame of reference here is Islam itself.

Let’s begin with the question of class experience. According to a World Bank study in the early 1980s, 52% to 67% of Kano’s urban population existed at the “absolute poverty level.” At least one-third of the Kano urban labor force was accounted for by the 15,000 or so small-scale enterprises (the vast majority in the trade sector), roughly 10% by formal sector industrial workers and perhaps another 20% were informal sector workers and the partially or fully unemployed (Frishman 1988). This subaltern class was occupationally diverse but had a social unity in terms of a popular self-identity in Hausa society as commoners (*talakawa*). A commoner (*talaka*) is “a person who holds no official position . . . a man in the street . . . a poor person” (Bargery 1934). As an indigenous social category it is of considerable antiquity, emerging from the social division of labor between town and countryside associated with the genesis of political kingdoms (the *sarauta* system) in the fifteenth century, and subsequently the emirate system of the Sokoto Caliphate (1806–1902), in which a lineage-based, office-holding class (*masu sarauta*) exercised political authority over subject populations. *Talakawa* refers, then, to a class relationship of a precapitalist sort but also a political relationship among status-honor groups with distinctive cultural identities and lifestyles. Naturally, the commoners have been differentiated in all sorts of complex ways through the unevenness of proletarianization – the indus-

trial working class for example constituting an important social segment of the commoners as such (Lubeck 1985).

While there is a generic sort of subaltern identity embodied in the notion of commoner, I wish to identify two distinctive social segments which are key to an understanding of Maitatsine's effort to "reshuffle" the Muslim self, namely, to return to a scripturalist form of piety based on the Qu'ran. Both are of some antiquity and are fashioned by locally distinctive social and cultural processes. The first concerns dry-season migrants (*'yan cin rani*) who circulate through the urban economy during the long dry season relieving pressures on domestic grain reserves in the countryside and who may generate limited savings which are typically of great value to dependent sons preparing for marriage. I would include in this category migrants who were, strictly speaking, not participants in seasonal circulatory networks but as a consequence of the urban construction boom and the collapse of agriculture were drawn into the Kano labor market in huge numbers. Almost wholly male, single, and young, and typically drawn from the densely settled and land-scarce northern provinces, they became semipermanent city residents, characteristically working in the so-called traditional occupations such as cart pushers, refuse collectors, and itinerant laborers.

This floating population expanded dramatically in the 1970s not only because of the urban construction boom, but also because of rural hardships, notably the devastating impact of drought and food shortage in the early 1970s and the dispossession of peasants due to land speculation, fraudulent land claims, and inadequate state compensations for suburban expansion and state irrigation schemes. In any event, these migrants shuttled into the northern cities such as Kano during the oil boom filling niches in the secondary labor market and constituting a young and increasingly alienated lumpen proletariat. According to Paul Lubeck (1987) almost 20% of the rural migrants who came to Kano during the 1970s were Muslim students (*almajiri*) or were sons of Islamic scholars. It was, however, precisely this informal sector employment which felt the pinch of declining real wages (due to high inflation) and the gradual displacement of traditional occupations due in large measure to the import boom and industrial substitution.⁹

The second segment of the commoners is associated with the system of informal Muslim schooling (*makarantar allo*), termed "Qu'ranic networks" by Paul Lubeck (1985, 1987), which linked city and country. These networks long predate the

9. According to Frishman *two-thirds* of the small-scale enterprises in Kano disappeared between 1973 and 1980, the lowest survival rates being in traditional occupations such as textiles, leather goods, enamel bowls, and shoe repair (1988: 16).

nineteenth century *jihad* and refer to a peripatetic tradition, rooted in the human ecology of the Sahel, in which students study with lay clerics (*mallams*) during the dry season. Students (*almajirai*) migrated to centers of Muslim learning such as Kano and typically studied the Qu'ranic science of exegesis at the feet of notable scholars often living in the entryways of homes of influential merchants and notables. Maitatsine was himself a product of this system. Islamic networks were sustained by a sort of urban moral economy – begging and alms-giving as part of a normative set of relations between rich and poor – which served to both extend Islam into the countryside and provide a measure of social and ideological integration for Hausa society as a whole. The students themselves often worked in the textile industry, acquiring important commercial and craft skills. In Kano these students are referred to as *gardawa*, although this is a semantically dense term which also refers to adult Muslim students, aspirant lay clerics of sorts, who may not be seasoned migrants as such but longer-term urban residents. As an ancient center of learning, of vigorous brotherhood activity, and of enormous mercantile wealth, Kano was quite naturally a major center of *gardawa* activity.

If commoners as a class (and the migrant and *gardawa* segments of it) represent a key set of structural preconditions through which many Kano residents experienced the oil boom, then what were the immediate or proximate qualities of that experience in civil society in urban Kano? I shall focus on three sets of processes which are framed by Cohen and Aarto's general definition of civil society as "structures of socialization, association, and organized forms of communication of the lifeworld" (1992: ix, x): state mediation in the form of corruption and violent but undisciplined security forces; urban social processes including the familial and associational spheres; and the return to civilian party politics in 1979.

I have already referred to the growing presence of the local and federal states in social and economic life. To this extent that the state was rendered much more visible in society by virtue of its expanded activities including road and office construction and contracting of various sorts, its visibility became synonymous with a total lack of moral responsibility and state accountability. In popular discourse, the state and government meant massive corruption on a Hobbesian scale. Graft through local contracts, import speculation, foreign exchange dealings, drug smuggling, hoarding of food, and so on proliferated on all levels of local and federal officialdom. It was commonplace to hear the Governor referred to as a thief, or the lament, "*Nigeria ta lalachi* (Nigeria has been ruined)." State ownership even implicated Islam itself: the Muslim brotherhoods owned shares in companies while the government was also centrally involved in the annual

migration of 100,000 pilgrims who participated in the *hadj*, a sacred event which was widely seen as a source of corruption and conspicuous consumption rather than an exercise in Muslim piety. In the return to civilian rule, state corruption reached unprecedented levels; as the commoners put it, “*siyasa ta bata duniya*—politics has spoiled the world.” When the home of the governor was searched in Kano in 1983, US\$5.1 million was found stacked up in cardboard boxes: primitive accumulation on a grand scale. At around the same time, 10% of the Nigerian GDP was “discovered” in an unnamed private bank account in Switzerland.

To put the matter bluntly, state mediation of the oil boom meant corruption, chaos, and bureaucratic indiscipline. Commoners were systematically denied access to a state they experienced as morally bankrupt, illegitimate, and incompetent. The police, who had been placed under federal jurisdiction, and the internal security forces were widely regarded as particularly corrupt, disorganized, and violent; they embodied the moral and political degeneracy of state power. In the context of rising urban crime, it was the police who proved to be the trigger for all sorts of community violence; they were uniformly feared and loathed by Kano’s urban poor. Indeed, it was the anti-riot police who perpetrated the slaughter of at least fourteen peasants at the Bakalori irrigation project in a conflict over land compensation which occurred six months prior to the Maitatsine insurrection. In the popular imagination the police were feared and were explicitly referred to as *daggal*—literally the devil.

At another level, the speeding up of Nigerian capitalism—the faster pace and rhythm of life unleashed by oil and state investment—was refracted throughout the lens of the urban community and associational life. The central issue here is not simply the anarchic and chaotic growth of Kano city—a terrifying prospect in itself—but also the changing material basis of commoners’ life and what it implied for the brute realities of urban living. First, urban land became a source of speculation for Kano merchants and civil servants, reflected in the fact that the price of urban plots in the working-class Tudun Wada neighborhood increased twenty-fold between 1970 and 1978. Land records invariably disappeared (usually through arson) and compensation for land appropriated by the state was arbitrary and a source of recurrent conflict. Second, the escalation of food prices, typically in the context of price-rigging, hoarding, and licensing scandals, far outstripped the growth of urban wages. The inflationary spiral in wage goods went hand in hand with both the internationalization of consumption by Kano’s elites—car ownership, for instance, grew by 700% in six years—and the erosion of many traditional occupations (mat-making, local building, donkey transport, leath-

erwork, cloth-beating [Frishman 1988]) of students and migrants within the secondary labor market.

Furthermore, the state-funded Universal Primary Education (UPE) program represented both an ideological attack by proponents of “western education” on the qu’ranic networks and associations, and an assault on the lay clerics and the students who sustained the informal Muslim schooling system. In Kano state, enrollment increased by 491% between 1973 and 1977 and in Hadejia emirate the number of primary schools leapt from thirty-six in 1970 to 392 in 1980. In the 1970s the lay clerics were vigorous critics of UPE, a discontentedness suggestive of a much broader crisis in the Muslim schooling system itself. Broadly put, the lineaments of an urban moral economy—similar in some respects to what Robert Putnam (1992) in a quite different cultural context has referred to as social capital—and of a number of informal public spheres are simultaneously rendered illegitimate and dysfunctional.

There is one final circumstance that is central to an understanding of the discursive space in which Maitatsine could flourish: the return to civilian rule in Nigeria in 1979 following a long period of military governance. In spite of the fact that the National Party of Nigeria (NPN)—the party of the conservative northern oligarchy—were victorious at the federal level and dominated several state legislatures, the populist/socialist People’s Redemption Party (PRP) swept to power in Kano State elections. The local government reforms of the 1970s had virtually eliminated the once powerful Native Authority officials who were replaced by university-educated administrators. However, the triumph of the PRP on a strong anti-aristocratic platform marked a qualitatively new political environment for the commoners. Much could be said about the PRP—not least its political split between “radical” and “conservative” factions—but in essence, the assertion of a populist, pro-commoner state government in Kano provided a political space in which the radical discourse of political Islam could operate and indeed be encouraged, not least insofar as it took as its starting point a critique of those Sufi brotherhoods most closely associated with the traditional emirate authorities and the feudal elements of the old northern ruling classes.

Civil Society and the Definition of Islamic Orthodoxy

Every religion . . . is in reality a multiplicity of distinct and contradictory religions: there is one Catholicism for the peasants, one for women and one for intellectuals which is itself variegated and disconnected.

Antonio Gramsci 1971: 420

[W]hat the ‘ulama [divines] are doing is to attempt a definition of orthodoxy—a (re)ordering of knowledge that governs the “correct” form of Islamic

practices. . . . This like all practical criticism seeks to construct a relation of discursive dominance. . . . [But] "Orthodoxy" is not easy to secure in conditions of radical change.

Talal Asad 1993: 210–211

Let me now turn to the question of capitalist modernity in relation to Islam, and the role and character of Islamism within the contours of civil society. In Nigeria, as elsewhere in the Muslim world, Islam is not a monolith but contains important institutional, ideological, and social organizational tensions and contradictions within its circumference.¹⁰ There have been, for example, struggles between and against the Sufi brotherhoods in Nigeria since the 1950s, and the effort by Ahmadu Bello to create the Jama'atu Nasril Islam (Organization for the Victory of Islam) in 1962 can be understood as an attempt to unite a *divided* Muslim community as a way of securing northern political hegemony in the newly independent Nigerian federation. But there is little question that over the past thirty or so years the fissiparous nature of the Muslim community has deepened, and by the 1970s polarization and conflict were increasing. A primary axis of difference and debate links the Sufi orders of brotherhoods—Quadriyya and Tijaniyya—to which many Nigerian Muslims are aligned, and newer so-called fundamentalist or anti-Sufi groups such as the powerful Jama'atu Izalat Al-Bidah Wa Iqamat Al Sunnah or Izala (roughly translated as the Removal of False Innovations and the Establishment of Orthodox Tradition) headed by Abubakar Gumi with strong connections to King Faisal of Saudi Arabia, and the Muslim Students Society (MSS), the latter being itself split between pro-Iranian and pro-Saudi factions (Ibrahim 1991).

These public debates which have spilled over on occasion into physical confrontations,¹¹ are not unrelated to the extraordinary ferment throughout the Muslim world during the last two decades and must be seen as exemplary of a much longer debate over Islamic orthodoxy. Indeed, Islam possesses a long tradition of revival (*tajdid*) and reform (*islah*) which is as much rooted *within* its own traditions as it is a response to Westernization in its various forms. Clerics, scholars, and religious leaders—representing in the Nigerian case differing Sufi and anti-Sufi constituencies—attempt to redefine Muslim orthodoxy in the context of radical social, economic, and political change by engaging in a long-standing Muslim tradition of public criticism. As Muslims, in other words, “their differ-

10. There is, of course, a unity within which there are “several traditions related to one another formally through common founding texts and temporally through diverging authoritative interpreters” (Asad: 1993: 236).

11. The Anigololu Tribunal noted 34 clashes between 1978 and 1980 in which “the rival groups were principally Izala, Tijaniyya and Qadiriyya” (Federal Government of Nigeria 1981a: 87).

ences are fought out on the ground of [orthodoxy]" (Asad 1993: 210) in an attempt to establish a discursive dominance.

Like other great traditions, Islam is also paradigmatic for its followers and its origins provide the normative basis of Muslim governance and personal conduct. At the heart of this paradigm, insofar as it shapes attitudes toward the state, society, wealth, and poverty, is the concept of justice. As Burke and Lubeck note, "popular Islamic ideas of justice . . . inhibit the flaunting of wealth and the taking of interest, and encourage charity. The scripturalist tradition . . . thus constrain the choices open to Muslim actors . . . and also provide repertoires of popular action and cultural vocabularies for their expression" (1987:649). Of course, these abstractions derived from texts and scripturalist discourses are filtered through local experiences and through quite contrary models of the Islamic polity. In the Sunni tradition (of which Nigeria is part), Burke (1986) distinguishes between the Rashidun model which roots justice and moral virtue in the early Muslim community and the strict application of the Shari'ah, and the imperial model of the later Arab caliphate which has been typically invoked by incumbent Islamic governments to justify *raison d'état* policies. Despite the distinctions and historical differences in political practice within the Sunni tradition, a normative thread runs through the great tradition, a search for justice in an unjust world that is analogous to the West European notion of a moral economy (Lubeck 1985, 1986). Like the European counterpart, the Islamic moral economy was a configuration of symbols and traditions to be interpreted, struggled over and fought for, but represented a series of cultural and moral norms which imposed particular expectations upon the rich, the clergy, and the ruling class more generally, as well as the commoners.

In light of my emphasis on flexibility, public criticism, and diversity, how might one characterize the communicative and institutional landscape of Islam in northern Nigeria which existed on the eve of the oil boom when Maitatsine was already active within Kano? I want to draw attention to two basic orientations within Kano Islam. The first concerns the shifting influence of the Sufi brotherhoods, specifically the Qadriyya which is associated with the holy war (*jihad*) of Usman dan Fodio in the early nineteenth century and more generally with the traditional northern Nigerian Hausa-Fulani aristocracy, and the Tijaniyya which had grown and flourished in the fertile soil of colonial politics and merchant-capitalism. In contradistinction to the Qadriyya which was party to a class alliance between the local Muslim ruling class and the colonial state, Tijaniyya contained specific radical, anti-colonial beliefs which appealed to a traditional merchant class operating in the interstices of the colonial economy (Paden 1973). Since

the 1960s, however, the hegemony of both brotherhoods has been contested by a number of anti-Sufi reformist sects in northern Nigeria—notably the Izala founded in 1978 by Mallam Idris in Jos in central Nigeria—whose aim is to abolish innovation and to practice Islam in strict accordance with the Qu’ran and the Sunnah. Anti-Sufi sentiment in Nigeria can be traced to the 1930s but it proliferated during and after the Second World War with the growth of a class of new elites who articulated both the virtues of the modern social transformations in contradistinction to the vices of tradition and an anti-colonial politics which turned on the question of the enhanced powers of “un-Islamic” emirs, imperialist lackeys who had willfully sidelined the legitimate authority and influence of the *ulama* (Umar 1993). Sa’ad Zungur (1915–1958) for example was an early critic of Sufi belief and of the colonial support of customary powers insofar as it rested, in his view, on the introjection of superstition (for example, polygamy, saint veneration, wife seclusion) into pristine Islam as practiced by the Prophet and the caliphs.

Since 1960, anti-Sufi movements have proliferated largely through the intellectual leadership and adroit communicational strategies of Sheikh Abubakar Gumi who has effectively used the Radio Television Kaduna, the Nigerian Television Authority, the Kaduna-based Hausa language newspaper *Gaskiya ta fi Kwabo*, and distributed taped cassettes of his *tafsir* sessions in the Sultan Bello Mosque in Kaduna to promote his message. In Gumi’s view, Sufism is not part of Islam because it emerged long after Islam had been completed; saint veneration is denounced as illegitimate and he rejects key Sufi concepts as invalid innovations, superfluous or un-Islamic (Umar 1988). Gumi argued persuasively for a positivistic conception of Islam which supersedes any sense of perfection through personal or subjective spiritual experience.

Referred to as the “new jihadists,” the doctrines of Izala are identical with Gumi’s views. While critical of the West’s decadence, they are neither antimodern nor antimaterialist in any simple sense, and hence are widely supported by the northern Nigerian intelligentsia and by aggressive new technocrats and businessmen. In some senses, Izala ideology “is to the Islamic brotherhoods what Protestantism is to Catholicism” (Gregoire 1993: 114). But it is also a form of protest against traditional noncapitalist values and against the perceived corruption of religious values and practices in the context of what Umar calls a “shift from communal to an individual mode of religiosity . . . in tune with the rugged individualism of capitalist social relations” (1993: 178). Whether Izala is simply a cathartic response to the tensions and frustration of Nigerian capitalism is less relevant for my concerns than the fact that its exegetical broadcasts, and its

polemics on the need for the separation of mosques contributed to a growing sense of cleavage and division within Kano city Islam, and to the wider legitimacy of anti-Sufi sentiment.¹² Indeed the very success of Izala had the effect of diluting the earlier tensions between Tijaniyya and Quadiriyya that had developed during a period of Sufi popularization in the 1950s, and unified the orders through new associational forms in 1977.¹³ This growing sense of public debate had the joint effect of fuelling the fire of so-called Islamic solutions to urban problems, and of deepening the Islamic saturation of civil society. Not only were more mosques built in Kano and their activities expanded, but at the same time Muslim institutions such as the Kano Foundation extended their activities to education, assistance for the poor and destitute, social mobilization, and maintaining public order.

The second dimension speaks to the shifting relations among the lay clerics (*ulama*), the teachers (*mallams*), and their associational forms. Many *mallams* are of course spokespersons for the brotherhoods and, to the extent that they are affiliated with state patronage, can be seen as pro-establishment (*malamin soro*). There is nonetheless a relatively independent laity associated in particular with the local qu'ranic schools of which there are three different forms. First, the primary schools (*makarantar allo*) for which the Qu'ran is the main (and sometimes the only) text, typically learned by rote at a seminary. Many of Maitatsine's followers were products of this system in which primary school teachers are typically independent, customarily sustained through alms. Then there is the higher school (*makarantar ilimi*) which ranges widely over theological and legal matters, and interpretation of the religious texts such as the hadith and the Qu'ran. Most higher school teachers are members of the brotherhood orders, and are paid for their instructional activities. And third, the so-called Islamiyya schools are primary and secondary, set up in the 1930s and expanded in the 1950s with a syllabus comparable to western forms of education but focusing on Arabic and Islamic studies.¹⁴ Since the 1970s, they have been funded by wealthy Muslim

12. The critique focuses especially on certain innovations: the folding of arms while praying, not facing Mecca while praying, collections of fees by mallams, and the wearing of amulets. The latter is especially interesting because it speaks to the belief popular in many segments of society in non-Muslim spirits and powers. It is precisely these sources of power (often associated in northern Nigeria with non-Muslim Hausa [Maguzawa] and the urban underworld) which Maitatsine drew upon; indeed Maitatsine was recognized as a sort of sorcerer. Several of Maitatsine's lieutenants carried talismans (one who is quoted in the *Aniagolu Report* said: "if I were cut into pieces and die I shall come back to life").

13. Specifically Kungiyar Jama'atu Ahlus-Sunnati and Kungiyar Dakarun Dan Fodio. See Umar (1993: 166–167) for an excellent account of these organizations.

14. Islamiyya schools are accredited (i.e., recognized by the state—indeed are state-funded in part), and their graduates are typically employed as judges and scribes in the northern emirates, and

businessmen and by philanthropic groups (for example, the Kano Foundation) with strong affiliations to particular local Muslim constituencies such as Izala.

Key to my argument is the growing tension between these Muslim networks and associations, and how these frictions reside within a larger debate over the differing weight and significance attributed to the Qu'ran, the hadith, the Sunnah, and to distinctive religious practices such as prayer, dress, and ritual. The migrant students (*gardawa*), seen as ignorant and traditional by both the higher school teachers and the Islamiyya scholars, did not enjoy the prestige and patronage of the state and characteristically were not appointed as local judges. The 'Yan Izala and the *gardawa* conversely occupied the same terrain in their anti-brotherhood beliefs.¹⁵ Both the *ilimi* and the *gardawa* were marginalised by the fact that the proliferation of Islamiyya schools (in conjunction with the growth of state-funded universal primary education during the oil years) systematically eroded their traditional networks.¹⁶ As Murray Last observes:

No longer now are there the eventual posts as respected village scholars now that the primary schools have their own religious instructors. No longer is there the ready hospitality (particularly in towns) and the same respect (or casual work) for the migrant students. Worst of all, perhaps, the class of austere pious, very learned yet public scholars, who once were the models for a particular way of life, has all but disappeared. (quoted in Barkindo 1993: 96)

A long time resident of Kano, Marwa witnessed these changes in the political and cultural economy of urban Kano during the frenetic oil years. As a charismatic preacher with a compelling, if idiosyncratic, reading of the Qu'ran, he recruited followers from the influx of migrants and students into the city and from the marginal underclass of Kano. Marwa's disciples recruited at the lorry parks and railway stations in Kano where they typically sustained themselves by selling tea and bread (Federal Government of Nigeria 1981b). His followers (migrants,

normally can gain entry into Nigerian universities. Many of the 'Yan Izalas are in fact products of the Islamiyya system, and Sheikh Gumi is perhaps its most distinguished and influential graduate. Many members of the Muslim Students Association are connected to the Islamiyya schools and have a scripturalist reading of Islam.

15. Associated with the brotherhoods, *darikat* practice involved daily prayer and meditation, strict discipline and obedience to saints.

16. I have not mentioned here the tradition of millenarian and Mahdist revolt in Nigeria which is important. The year 1979 was also the onset of the new century in the Muslim calendar which was widely held to promise the coming of the Mahdi.

itinerant workers, *gardawa*) were products of the same qu'ranic system as himself; most of his Kano followers were educated in the traditional primary school system. Furthermore, Marwa's use of syncretist and pre-Islamic powers resonated strongly with migrants from the countryside where vestiges of ancient Hausa metaphysical belief remained quite influential. Slowly Marwa was able to build up an enclave in 'Yan Awaki fashioned around a disciplined, and self-consciously austere, egalitarian community of Muslim brothers who supported themselves largely through alms, although land and urban gardens were appropriated to support the devotees.¹⁷ Marwa's unorthodox and literalist interpretation of the Qu'ran focused specifically on the icons of modernity: bicycles, watches, cars, money. But it would be mistaken to view Maitatsine as antimodern or primevalist in any simple sense. The movement employed modern arms when necessary, and Marwa emphasized the ill-gotten quality of goods and not their inherent illegitimacy. Likewise his desire to seize key institutions in Kano city—the radio station and the state electricity company—is hardly antimodernist. Kano merchants, bureaucrats, and elites were implicated in his critique, but he targeted the state for its moral bankruptcy and the police as its quintessential representatives. Any affiliation to the state naturally contaminated Islamic practice.

Not surprisingly, commodities and money, in fact, loomed large in Marwa's preaching. The basis of his provocative reading of the Qu'ran as the *only* valid guide to human conduct rested on the revelation of hidden meanings within the sacred text, and in his rooting of verse in local conditions. Marwa's vehement denunciation of cigarettes, motor vehicles, buttons, and western-style apparel, was revealed through his careful textual analysis. Marwa interpreted Qu'ranic texts in part by playing on the meanings and phonetic associations of certain Hausa and Arabic words. Furthermore, he played creatively with the relations between signs and their referents. In his public preaching he pointed to the physical similarity between the Arabic character for Allah and a simple graphical depiction of a bicycle. This homology not only validated his accusation that all persons who rode bicycles were by definition pagan but also confirmed his far-reaching attack on the corruption and degeneration of Islam at the highest levels. The sense of moral crisis in a curious way lent both credibility and legitimacy to Maitatsine's ideas because there is within Islamic eschatology a strong belief in "Signs of the Hour," the idea that at the end of every century (which in the Muslim

17. According to Saad (1988: 118), a survey conducted among the arrested *'yantatsine* revealed that 95% believed themselves to be Muslim.

calendar fell in 1979) a leader may appear to restore order, to renew and regain the world that has been lost.

To put the argument starkly, Nigeria's oil-based fast capitalism was mapped onto civil society; in practice this produced a gradual colonization of the Kano lifeworld by the steering media of petrolic capitalism. Fast capitalism was experienced by a differentiated, heterogeneous and transnational Muslim community in Nigeria which became the forum for a particular sort of public debate.¹⁸ The growing popularity and following of Izala, the Muslim Students Society, and other fundamentalist groups in relation to the powerful brotherhoods suggests an important struggle over orthodox Islam was already under way in Nigeria by the early 1970s, and that cultural and religious capital relevant to these debates was drawn from a transnational Muslim community. Participation in the pilgrimage to Mecca, the geographic circulation of religious elites through transnational networks such as the brotherhoods, and the consumption of new ideas through radio and circulating audio cassettes were all relevant to this vibrant, and not infrequently acrimonious, public discourse—indeed to reasoning within the circumference of a particular tradition—within Islam.

Maitatsine was, in this regard, legitimately part of a wide-ranging public discourse within the public sphere of the northern Nigerian Muslim community. The language of reformism (if not necessarily radical Islamism) resonated with large sections of northern Nigerian society and Maitatsine enjoyed a hearing and a measure of serious attention, as Bawuro Barkindo properly put it, “partly because many . . . people who did not join him agreed with the *content of his preaching*” (1993:98; my emphasis). Maitatsine was no more an “isolated fanatic” than the panoply of Islamisms and its complex genesis is simply fundamentalist. Powerful economic and political forces marginalised the popular laity and their followers (*gardawa*) to whom Maitatsine spoke and to some extent represented in Kano city, and this permitted Maitatsine to resurrect a debate dating back at least to the colonial conquest and had in a sense never ceased. This debate condemned the European world and advocated return to a time in which Islam could be practiced without hindrance. Just as Islam in general had succeeded in penetrating and refiguring civil society in the course of the twentieth century, so too Maitatsine's excavation of and deliberations on an older debate carried a great deal of popular legitimacy and interest. It was the marginalization of a long-standing

18. This is to make the point that Nigerian clerics, students, and Muslims more generally travelled to North Africa and the Middle East (via the *hadj*) and were familiar with debates within Islam in these places.

and institutionalized form of traditional Muslim learning, and the exploitation of the Maitatsine movement by larger political forces which ultimately propelled Marwa to both establish and violently defend an *independent* religious community within the old city walls of Kano that actively pursued and promoted a utopian vision.

The Maitatsine movement had neither the resources nor the organizational capacity of some other forms of political Islam—for example FIS in Algeria or Musa Sadr's Movement of the Deprived in Lebanon—nor was it capable of seizing state power. But what is known of the followers and of those who tacitly lent their support, endorses what seems to be a much broader pattern of the coalitional character of Islamism. Most of these movements are, as Richards (1995) notes, fissiparous and cellular but they are typically composed of a counterelite of Islamist businessmen and professionals whose opportunities are limited by the old order, a stratum of alienated and frustrated educated young men and women from the larger cities,¹⁹ and a mass of the urban poor who constitute what Roy calls "lumpen-Islamism" (1994:84). Most students of political sociology agree that the typical profile of the militant is a younger person (usually male) with some education who is a recent urban migrant (Denoeux 1993; Ayubi 1991; Richards 1995; Roy 1994). In this sense the 'yantatsine (Marwa's followers) were almost archetypal: they were uniformly poor (80% had income well below the minimum wage) with a not insubstantial tacit support from a number of students, well-placed professionals, businessmen, and commoners at large. In general, however, the genesis of Marwa and his wide-ranging networks of affiliation can only be fully comprehended in terms of the material and status deprivation of 'yantatsine recruits scrambling to survive in an increasingly chaotic and Hobbesian urban environment punctuated by the unprecedented ill-gotten wealth and corruption of the dominant classes in urban Kano.

Community, Identity, Reason: Islamism and the Very Idea of Civil Society

Islam is taking on new meanings as Muslims assert the centrality of Islam in public and private life. . . . Understanding Islamic fundamentalism as an expression of modernity rather than tradition yields insights into its

19. Many of these frustrated students suffer from sour grapes: "they hate modernity because they cannot get it! The Islamists are angry not because the aeroplane has replaced the camel; they are angry because they could not get on the aeroplane" (Ayubi 1991: 177).

powerful appeal and draws attention to the social and economic processes associated with its spread.

Victoria Bernal 1994: 38

Territorial place-based identity, particularly when conflated with race, gender, religious and class differentiation, is one of the most pervasive bases for both progressive political mobilization and reactionary exclusionary politics.

David Harvey 1993: 4

Maitatsine's Islamism as a particular form of invented tradition represents a dramatic political expression of the changing cultural geography of Nigerian capitalism. It was "fast capitalism" grounded in nonunitary Muslim tradition that provided the material and symbolic raw material from which a distinctive sense of self and of communitarian identity was forged in Kano. The oil boom had fashioned a period of "space-time compression" to use Harvey's (1989) felicitous phrase, and its powers of creative destruction were transmitted through a specific articulation of two world-systemic processes: Islam and capitalism. Each system was both global and local in its constitution; as a global abstraction each force field was experienced, transmitted, and contested in demonstrably local ways.

My concern here has been to say something about the genesis of *modern* political Islam in relation to globalizations and specific national capitalisms, but in so doing to also explore the relations between Islam and civil society understood in terms of the democratic character of social relations and communications between citizens. It is not simply a question of Tocquevillian notions of association and civility, but also the idea of a public sphere as developed by Habermas and extended by Fraser: namely, a "theater . . . in which political participation is enacted through the medium of talk. It is the space in which citizens deliberate about their common affairs, hence an institutionalized arena of discursive interaction . . . which can on principle be critical of the state" (Bryant 1993:399). If this public sphere is the site of the production of hegemony (as Gramsci notes in his various discussions of the state), then an understanding of the role of Islam *both* as a potential source of criticism of the state *and* as a means by which "philosophies" or "conceptions of the world" assist the ruling bloc in exerting leadership over a variety of groups within political society,²⁰ can provide a counterpoint to the essentialist and Weberian views of Islam. In particular, one can

20. This is what I take O'Hanlon to mean when she says that "each form of the hegemonic comes into existence around diversities of interest and potential sites for resistance which fracture and constrain it even as it exerts its conforming power" (1988: 34).

question Ernest Gellner's (1983, 1992) explanation of Islam as an alternative route to modernity in which the urban scripturalism and legalism of the *ulama* is analogous to Weber's puritan ethic. In this view, puritanical Islam is a modern renewal of its historical essence in which economic development is possible but at the cost of political stagnation and the collapse of civil society (which is subsumed or displaced by religion; see Zabaida 1995).

The Maitatsine insurrection represented a powerful, if counterhegemonic, reading and critique of the Nigerian oil boom and of the Nigerian ruling classes. To this extent one should not be diverted by the syncretist character of the leader, by his purported use of magic, by possible Mahdist overtones, and by accusations of fundamentalist fanaticism. Marwa's self-identity, including his prophethood, is perhaps of less relevance than his antimaterialist, class-based reading of the moral superiority of the Qu'ran which led him to attack decadence, profligacy, and moral decay. Critical of public corruption, of arbitrary police violence, and of some forms of private property, he fashioned a community largely of young men—unskilled migrants, Qu'ranic scholars, and rural destitutes—who were products of the shifting relations between town and countryside during the 1970s. His critique of materialism and the West was nonetheless ambiguous and contradictory: on the one hand he rejected some aspects of modernity in his invocation of a simple disciplined life, and yet he also invoked a political vision in which the control of modern institutions was central.

Oil and Islam no more determine radical critique or indeed insurrectional politics than does a mixture of copper and Christianity. But Maitatsine's form of Muslim populism possessed a great capacity to resist cooptation, providing in his case a culturally convincing critique of "oil prosperity," and a powerful ideology in weak Islamic states experiencing the radical dislocation of the petrolic capitalism. The Maitatsine followers constituted a certain disenfranchised segment of the northern popular classes who experienced, handled, and resisted a particular form of capitalism through a particular reading of Islamic tradition. It is a truism that Islam is a text-based religion, but we need to grasp the relationships between texts and the meanings they are purported to provide, what Lambek calls local hermeneutics:

The specific problems raised by the translation of objective meaning of written language into the personal act of speaking . . . [is an act of] appropriation. . . . The nature of texts and the knowledge to be drawn from them in any given historical context are shaped by a sociology or political economy of knowledge: how textual knowledge is reproduced . . . what social

factors mediate access to texts, who is able to read and in what manner, who has the authority to represent . . . and how challenges to such authority are manifested. (1990: 23-24)

Islam is a text-based religion that is made socially relevant through citation, reading, enunciation, and interpretation, and in this sense Islam is not prescriptive in simple ways providing unambiguous guidance for its adherents (Fischer and Abedi 1990). Indeed, as Fischer and Abedi have brilliantly shown in their book *Debating Muslims*, there is a dialogic and hermeneutical tradition within Islam rooted in the enigmatic, oral, performative, and esoteric qualities of the Qu'ran. The same religious symbols can be infused with radically different meanings. Tradition itself is constantly negotiated, contested, and reinvented in the context of efforts by rulers and clerics to enforce other meanings in a world turned upside down by oil monies. There is a multiplicity of Muslim voices, and it was the mapping of local Islam onto local capitalism which threw these religious multiplicities into bold relief, generating intense struggles over the meaning of Islam and the Muslim community.²¹

The community that was built in 'Yan Awaki was a peculiar and parochial affair; little of substance was said about political horizons beyond the ward in which Marwa and his followers resided. Like other oppositional utopian movements (in this case the golden age is the time of Medina), its ability to present a serious and modern Islamic alternative depends on its capacity to "transform cultural solidarity, social discipline and informally organized services into an alliance capable of delivering existing services and a new development strategy capable of coping with the demands of the new global economy" (Lubeck 1995: 53). In this more profound sense Maitatsine was hopelessly inadequate to the modern task of building a transnational, unified community governed by universal Islamic law and underwritten by a state to enforce it. The Maitatsine movement contained, to concur with Harvey's assessment above, both critical and exclusionary politics in a vision that fused religion and class. Its limited perspective and reach—Maitatsine never talked about managing the economy, regulating foreign policy, or processes of globalization—had much to do with a horizon limited by the nationalist sense of political economy associated with informal Muslim schooling. Yet, this was not a simple return to some mythical past but rather involved contesting some Islamic traditions and creating new ones by a direct

21. For similar arguments within Muslim discourse in relation to capitalism, see Ong 1990 and Lambek 1990.

engagement with capitalist modernity read through new scripturalist understandings of Islam. At the same time, their projection into the maelstrom of fast capitalism compelled Maitatsine to engage his scripturalist concerns, however inadequately, with the much larger world of contemporary capitalism. To this extent, as Schorske suggests, there was a revising of beliefs and a search for an identity that took the form of a specific, and contradictory reshuffling of the self. The dramatic way in which oil threw together the old and the new—a sort of combined and uneven development—makes this reshuffling and the placed-based identities so produced, a curious and in some respects fantastic sort of enterprise.

If Maitatsine appears as a relatively parochial sort of political Islam, it nonetheless contains within it a compelling story with respect to Islam and state-society relations in general and poses a number of fundamental questions about the politics of anti-Sufi movements in Nigeria. On the one hand, it is incontestable that Islam had moderated relations between the state and society in postcolonial states. The brotherhoods in this sense exemplify those capacities required of *any* civil society if it is to curb the hegemony of the state (Villalon 1995:259): their capacity to aggregate interests, an autonomy which commands the engagement of the state in order to govern, and a strategic flexibility in relation to state action. Further, the anti-Sufi movements in Nigeria began as an anti-imperialist but modernist assault on noncapitalist traditional values, even if in their more recent incarnation such as Izala, they have assumed a more conservative political cast. Through its prayer meets, its *tafsir*, its public debate, and use of modern communications, the discipline, accessibility, and probity of its institutions, and not least its dense web of associations that provide valued health, welfare, and educational services, Islam acts as both an alternative political and economic platform to the state and a critical oppositional discourse. Islam and Islamism in Nigeria, then, sound a warning to the widespread belief that African societies have tended to be ineffective counterweights to African states.

The Maitatsine and anti-Sufi movements also confirm that Islamism is modern, and as Zabaida says (1995), a political ideology quite distinct from anything in Muslim history. It is not simply that Islam has become the idiom in which a vast array of often contradictory interests and frustrations are discussed in a manner previously associated with secular nationalisms and Marxism. It is also that Islamism has a genealogy which does not simply repeat the *essential* character of Islam—an unbroken lineage from the eighteenth century or earlier to the contemporary Egyptian brotherhoods—as Gellner and others suggest (Burke 1995). Much of Islamism is new and modern because it engages with and provides a public and reasoned discourse about a number of topics relevant to liberalism

such as constitutionalism, democracy, representative government, economics, and gender. Indeed, as Kramer (1993) points out, Islamist discourse is quite fluid and unstable on issues such as pluralist democracy, protection of human rights, and state accountability. Islamism also innovates in attempting to locate the means by which it can articulate a vision that simultaneously claims membership in a transnational community and a national polity (Lubeck 1995).

Villalon (1995: 265) is surely right to express skepticism about any claim which purports to see an intrinsically democratic relationship in the ways in which Islam links state and society. Religious criticism within the Kano and anti-Sufi sphere is limited and limiting; there are things that cannot be criticized and choices that are not permitted. But as Asad says, these limitations are “due not to a permanent incapacity to contemplate change, still less to an intrinsic contradiction between religion and reason” (1993: 232). This observation was of course at the heart of Gramsci’s interest in religion and it is to Gramsci that I turn for insight into the conditions under which religion can challenge dominant hegemonies and create an oppositional culture based on what he called “critical understanding.” It is my claim that the foundation of this critical understanding—free spaces and autonomous organizations, organic intellectuals, and social interaction to ensure the plausibility and sustenance of new world views (see Billings 1990)—can be read into Kano Islamism, and even into the myopia of the Maitatsine movement itself.

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